

Temporary Help Services in the United States

Employment, wages, and demographics from the Census Quarterly Workforce Indicators

Prepared from U.S. Census QWI microdata

September 9, 2026

Outline

- 1 Motivation and data
- 2 National employment
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Why temporary help services?

- Temporary help agencies (**NAICS 561320**) place workers on their own payroll at client firms. The sector is a bellwether: firms add and shed temps before permanent staff.
- It is also a large, low-wage segment of the labour market and the single biggest piece of *Administrative and Support Services* (NAICS 56).
- Questions addressed in this analysis:
 - 1 How has national temp employment moved across the 2008–09 recession, the 2010s expansion, and the pandemic?
 - 2 How large is temp help *relative to* its parent sector?
 - 3 How do temp wages compare with the sector and with all private employment — and is the gap changing?
 - 4 Who works in the sector (sex, age)?

Data and method

Source. Census *Quarterly Workforce Indicators* (QWI), LEHD program, via the API endpoint `timeseries/qwi/sa`. Quarterly, not seasonally adjusted.

Geography. State-level counts for the 50 states + DC, summed to a national total. Earnings are *employment-weighted* across states.

Coverage. 2005–2024 where available; the temp-help series is complete from 2005. Suppressed cells (flags N/D/S) are dropped.

Industries compared

561320	Temporary Help Services
56	Admin. & Support Services
00	Total private sector
561311	Employment Placement
561312	Executive Search
561330	Prof. Employer Orgs (PEO)

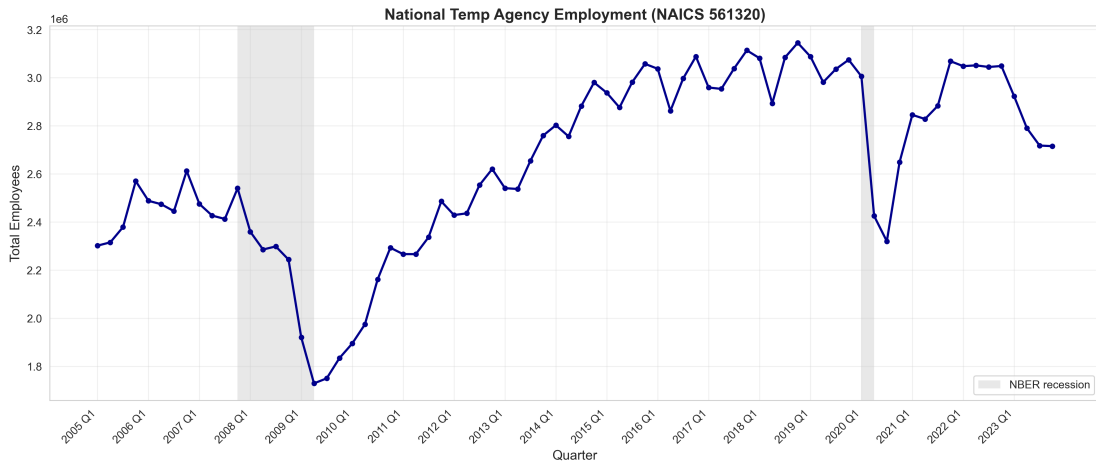
Key measures

Emp — beginning-of-quarter employment

EarnS — avg. monthly earnings, full-quarter workers

EarnHirAS — avg. monthly earnings, new hires

National temp employment, 2005–2023

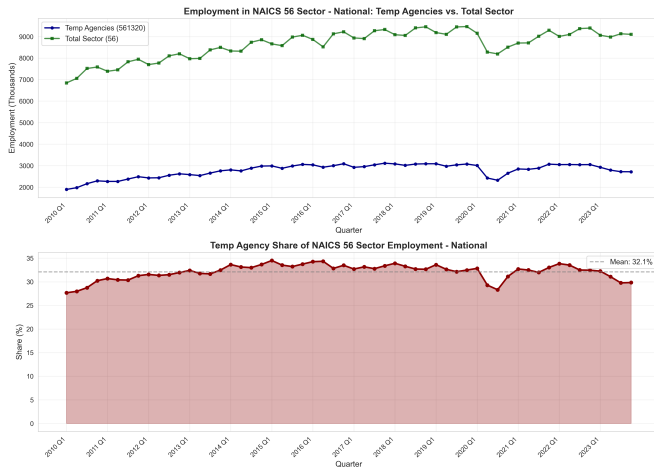


Source: QWI NAICS 561320, sum of 50 states + DC. Not seasonally adjusted.

National temp employment — what the series shows

- **Great Recession:** fell from 2.61 million (2006 Q4) to 1.73 million (2009 Q2), a drop of about **34%** — far deeper than the total-employment decline.
- **2010s expansion:** steady recovery; the prior peak was surpassed by 2014 and employment reached about 3.14 **million** (2018 Q4).
- **Pandemic:** 3.01 million (2020 Q1) → 2.32 million (2020 Q3), **–23%** in two quarters, then a rapid rebound to $\approx$ 3.05 million through 2022.
- **2023 slowdown:** down about **11%** from the 2022 peak to 2.72 million by 2023 Q4 — back to 2015 levels, and consistent with temp help leading the broader labour-market cycle.
- Strong seasonality: Q4 is always the local high (holiday-quarter staffing), Q2 typically the low.

Temp help as a share of Administrative & Support Services (NAICS 56)



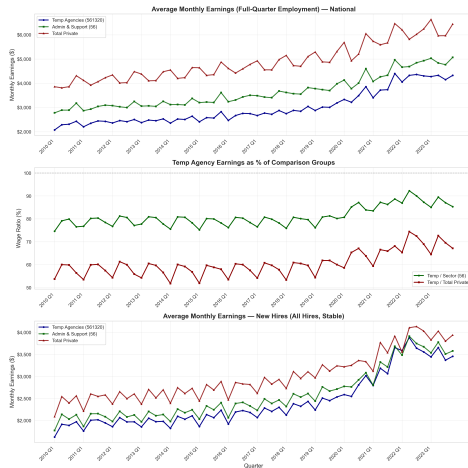
Source: QWI: NAICS 561320 employment $\div$ NAICS 56 employment, national.

Share of NAICS 56 — roughly one-third, and cyclical

Year	Temp share of NAICS 56 (%)
2010	28.7
2013	32.1
2015	33.8
2019	32.7
2020	30.4
2022	33.1
2023	30.7

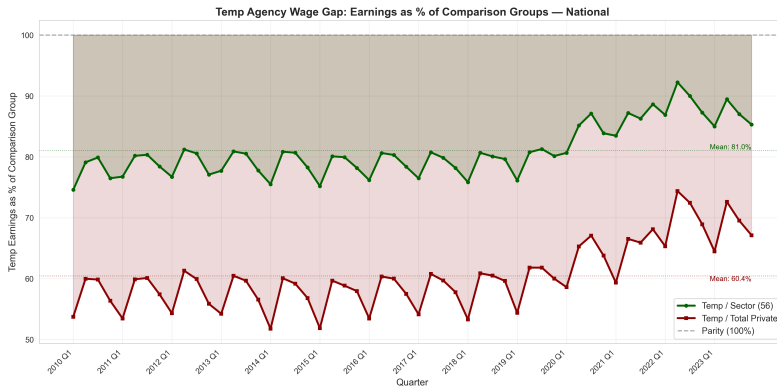
- Temp help is consistently **28–34%** of all Administrative & Support Services employment.
- The share *rose* through the early 2010s recovery, then flattened near one-third.
- It falls in downturns (2020, 2023): temp jobs are cut first, so the sub-sector shrinks faster than its parent.

Earnings: temp agencies vs. sector vs. all private



Source: QWI EarnS / EarnHirAS, employment-weighted national averages, 2010–2023.

The temp wage gap — large, but narrowing



Source: Temp EarnS as a percentage of the comparison group; dotted lines are period means.

Wages — key numbers

Average monthly earnings (EarnS)

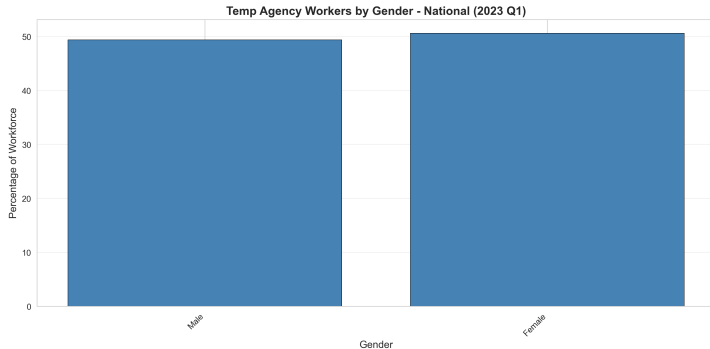
Year	Temp	NAICS 56	Private
2010	2274	2934	3960
2015	2594	3311	4550
2019	3022	3797	5087
2022	4261	4783	6071
2023	4269	4926	6250

Temp earnings as % of ...

Year	NAICS 56	Private
2010	78	57
2019	80	59
2023	87	68

- Period averages (2010–23): **81%** of the sector, **60%** of all private.
- The gap narrowed most in **2020–2022**, when a tight labour market bid up temp pay.
- For *new hires*, temp pay is much closer to parity — $\approx 97\%$ of sector, 89% of private in 2023.

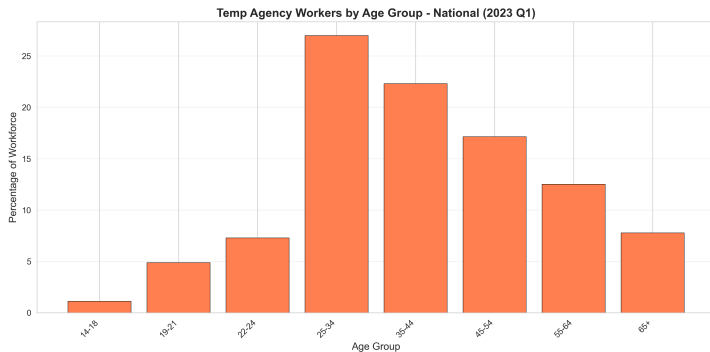
Who works in temp help? — Sex (2023 Q1, national)



- Male **49.4%** / Female **50.6%**.
- Essentially even — close to the overall private-sector split, unlike the male-dominated image of light-industrial staffing.

Source: QWI NAICS 561320, sex breakdown, 48–49 states with unsuppressed data.

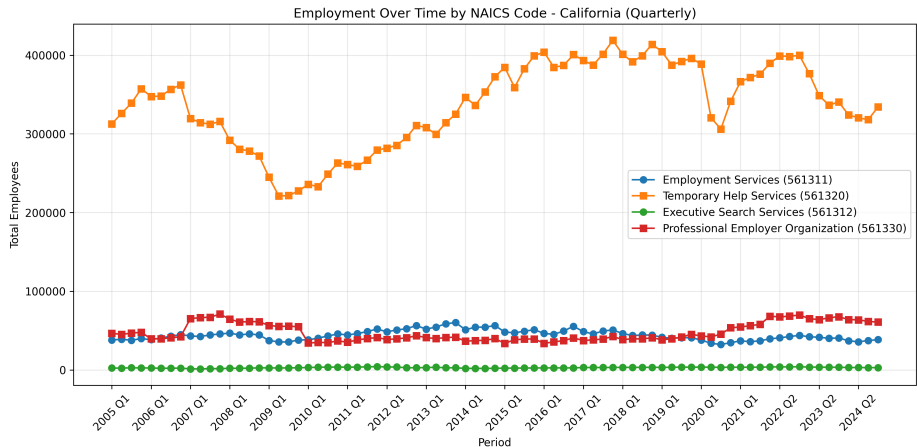
Who works in temp help? — Age (2023 Q1, national)



Age	%
14-24	13.3
25-34	27.0
35-44	22.3
45-54	17.1
55+	20.3

- About **two-thirds** are prime-age 25–54.
- Younger than the workforce overall, but not a youth sector — one in five workers is 55+.

Employment-services sub-sectors (California, 2005–2024)



Source: QWI NAICS 561311/561320/561312/561330, California.

Employment services — temp help dominates

- In California, **561320 (temp help)** is roughly **5–6×** the size of the rest of employment services combined — about 326k jobs in 2005, a peak near 399k in 2022, then a sharp fall to 320k by 2024.
- **561330 (PEOs)** grew from $\approx 45\text{k}$ to $\approx 64\text{k}$, with a step-up after 2021.
- **561311 (employment placement)** is flat near 40k; **561312 (executive search)** is tiny ($\approx 3\text{k}$).
- The single-state script (`temp_agencies_over_time.py`) tracks the same California 561320 series, mirroring the national pattern: -39% in 2008–09, an all-time peak near 419k (2017 Q4), the 2020 dip, and a slide from 400k (2022) toward 330k (2024).

Takeaways

- 1 **Amplified cycle.** Temp employment swings far more than total employment — -34% in 2008–09, -23% in early 2020, and an 11% decline through 2023 that led the broader slowdown.
- 2 **Stable structural weight.** Despite the swings, temp help holds near **one-third** of Administrative & Support Services.
- 3 **Persistent but shrinking wage gap.** Temp workers earn about **80%** of sector pay and **60%** of all-private pay on average; both ratios rose markedly in 2020–2022 and remained higher through 2023. New-hire pay is close to parity.
- 4 **Broad workforce.** Roughly even by sex; concentrated in prime working ages but with meaningful shares both under 25 and over 55.

Caveats

- QWI is a by-product of state UI records; small state $\times$ quarter $\times$ demographic cells are suppressed, so demographic totals rest on 48–49 states, not all 51 jurisdictions.
- Series are **not seasonally adjusted**; compare like quarters or annual averages.
- “Employment” is a count of jobs (beginning-of-quarter), not full-time-equivalents; temp assignments are short, so headcount overstates labour input relative to other sectors.
- The education breakdown returns all zeros for this industry (a QWI data-availability limit) and is omitted.
- California is used for the sub-sector and single-state views; national patterns may differ.

Thank you

Code and figures: `code/` and `output/` in the `Temp_agencies` repository.